

LIFE+TRAVEL

Equine connection

The bond between officers and horses in the Chicago Police Department's Mounted Patrol Unit is built on trust, training.

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BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A+E

Rebuilding hope

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Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, MARCH 16, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Making amends

Cook County assessor's office fixes hundreds of misclassified properties following a Tribune-Illinois Answers investigation

By Alex Nitkin and A.D. Quig

This story is a collaboration between the Illinois Answers Project and the Chicago Tribune.

Nearly half a billion dollars in taxable real estate value has been added onto the Cook County rolls after the county assessor fixed hundreds of mistakes identified in an investigation by the Illinois Answers Project and Chicago Tribune.

The corrections come as Cook County Assessor Fritz Kaegi's office in recent months audited key records tied to thousands of properties across the county following last August's report, which found the office had misclassified and undervalued properties by missing new construction and significant property improvements.

In all, using publicly available sales and satellite data, the Tribune and Illinois Answers found the office had failed to accurately assess at least 620 new or renovated properties

Above: Raphael Espinoza, left, and Skylar Damiano play with their cat, Patch, in the kitchen of their Humboldt Park home on March 6. For about 2 1/2 years, the pair have lived in their newly constructed house, which has been taxed erroneously as a vacant side lot. The assessor's office assured them the property assessment will be updated and that they won't have to pay back taxes. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

during the 2023 tax year. In some instances, Kaegi's office assessed mansions as vacant lots and missed the bulk of two new subdivisions in a far south suburb.

Kaegi's office has downplayed the findings as a small portion of the county's overall tax base that would have little effect on other homeowners' bills. Still, his office moved forward with the internal audit that eventually revealed even more properties were improperly classified, though his office will not say how many. In the past several months, the assessor has also hired or promoted staffers — including the top official overseeing data integrity — and sharpened office processes that previously resulted in inaccurate tax bills and hundreds of millions of dollars in missed value that should have been taxed.

"These changes are central to our ongoing work to modernize our operations, make our own work more efficient, and ensure that the property tax system is fair and accessible for all Cook County residents," assessor's office spokesperson Christian Belanger wrote in a

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Health insurance program faces axe

Pritzker looks to curtail benefits for some immigrants

By Laura Rodríguez Presa and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Despite being born with malformed limbs and later giving birth to four children, Francisca avoided going to the doctor as much as possible for about two decades.

The 58-year-old Southwest Side resident lacked health insurance, so when she got sick or was in pain she often relied on home remedies. When she had a toothache, she wouldn't go to the dentist.

Nearly two years ago, though, Francisca's situation changed dramatically. She obtained health coverage through a state program that provides taxpayer-funded insurance to immigrants like her who are in the country without legal permission as well as green card holders who haven't been in the U.S. long enough to qualify for Medicaid, the traditional health care program for the poor.

When she had her first dental cleaning after getting the state-funded coverage, "it felt like a blessing," said Francisca, who asked to be identified by only her first name because of her immigration status.

But in just a few months, Francisca and more than 30,000 other immigrants in Illinois may be uninsured once again as Gov. JB Pritzker has proposed eliminating funding for the program that began in 2022 for noncitizen immigrants ages 42 to 64.

While coverage would continue for noncitizen immigrants 65 and older, cutting the program for the 42-to-64 age group is a significant piece of Pritzker's plan to balance a \$55.2 billion state budget proposal. The governor estimates it will save \$330 million as costs are rising and growth in income and sales taxes is slowing, developments that continue to strain the state's finances and force difficult deci-

Turn to Insurance, Page 4

INSIDE



Batter up! Season preview for MLB '25

Cubs outfielder Ian Happ hopes pairing with Justin Turner will spark a playoff push. Plus, can the Sox bounce back from a nightmarish 2024? We have outlooks for every team and expert predictions.

Section inside subscribers' copies

Deadly storms batter parts of the country

Violent tornadoes ripped through parts of the country, wiping out schools and toppling tractor-trailers in several states, part of a monster storm that killed at least 26 people. **Nation & World**

Longer commute on 'L' as slow zones grow

In February, they covered some 30% of CTA's rail system

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

Before Rory Hoskins stopped regularly taking the CTA Blue Line into downtown Chicago, his once-typical "L" commute had already gotten noticeably slower.

The train would crawl and sometimes stop on its way to and from Forest Park, during peak commuting hours and midday alike. Traveling over the same 10 miles of track seemed like it had gotten less reliable over the years, and as his commute home got longer he was discouraged from riding the train as often.

"It just seemed like it was taking longer to get to the same place," said Hoskins, who became mayor of Forest Park in 2019.

In the years since, CTA trains have only gotten slower, forced

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Passengers exit as CTA Blue Line trains prepare to head in different directions toward Forest Park and east to downtown Chicago at the Kedzie-Homan CTA station in Chicago on Friday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 39 Low 27

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 18

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
177th year No. 75 © Chicago Tribune

